

didn't support scripting or creation of dynamic Web pages.

However, now, most Web authoring software allow you to add JavaScript functionality without having to actually write code and you can just add, say, a mouse rollover function, with the click of a mouse! While you cannot create a complete dynamic Web page without having to do even one bit of coding, Web authoring tools have certainly eased the task by automating most of the tedious and repetitive aspects of coding.

In all, we tested 10 Web authoring tools that have been around for quite some time, but have improved functionality now. Software such as Adobe GoLive 5, Namoeditor and FrontPage 2002 even employ database operands to make your task even more simpler.

Other software such as HotMetal Pro, Dreamweaver, etc, have been favourites with Web developers and are becoming easier to use with each new version.

Text matters

Text formatting is the most basic of tasks that you would expect from a Web authoring package, and none disappoint with respect to these basics. You have the facility of importing text in most of them, and then working on formatting the text in terms of alignment, fonts, colours, etc.

With packages such as Macromedia Dreamweaver or Namo WebEditor, you almost feel as if you are working in Microsoft Word, such is the ease of use and functionality that you get. These packages had a very minimal learning curve in terms of trying to understand the icons, menu locations for common tasks or toolbars for one-stop formatting options.

Though text insertion on a Web page is such an elementary feature, we couldn't help but wonder why software like NetObjects Fusion and Tarantula had unnecessarily complicated it by forcing the user to insert a text box on the Web page first and only then allowing you to work on the text.

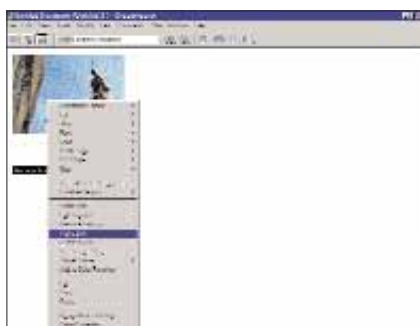
Linking spree: What's an HTML page without hyperlinks? Obviously, all the packages had made it quite simple to create links to text. All you had to normally do was select the text, click on the link icon on the toolbar, and in the window specify the target URL or range.

Only with Dreamweaver, though, we found options to specify whether the target URL should be opened in the same

TEST PROCESS

We tested the Web authoring software by creating a Web page template that had most of the elements any standard Web page would have. We checked for whether all of these feature parameters were available in the tools and whether they were also easily accessible. To be specific, we examined the Web authoring software for their ability to handle text and images, create forms and tables, and other miscellaneous features. For instance, we tested by creating a page with Cascading Style Sheets (CSS), and adding other text formatting options such

as bullets, lists, etc, and linking it to other pages. In image handling, we imported an image, and tried to resize and reposition it, as also create hotspots (or mapped areas). While creating tables, we looked for support for nested tables and mechanisms to change the border size, cell padding and cell width. Forms were looked at for pre-defined templates for creating fields and options in different fields such as drop-down list, combo boxes, etc. Other features checked out were those relating to interface, navigational tools, etc.

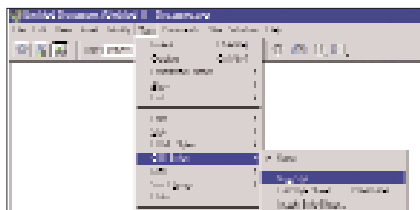


Creating links is easy with Dreamweaver

window or a new window, right there within the toolbar options itself. In addition, you could even specify the placement of the new windows, like, say, the centre of left of your screen—this is an amazing amount of control.

Cascading effect: Text handling is really made simple through the use of Cascading Style Sheets (CSS). CSS allows you to specify formatting attributes (font, text size, colour, etc) to a text and create a style that can be universally applied across the Web page. So, for instance, you can create a style for headings, another style for captions, a third for numbered lists, etc.

Unfortunately, it wasn't that easy to locate the CSS options in most of the software. You had to either check the help files or navigate around the menu items. However, with Dreamweaver and GoLive



Dreamweaver allows you to format text using Cascading Style Sheets

we faced no such problem. CoolPage and NetUp were two software that didn't have options for CSS at all.

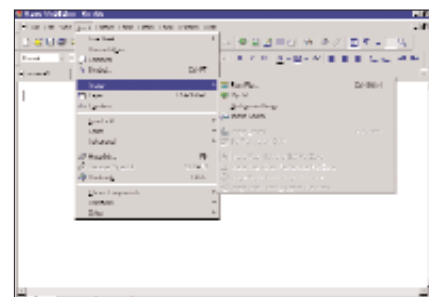
Image mapping

You've heard the phrase before, 'a picture speaks a thousand words'. Well, we repeat it, because there is nothing like an image to create an impression though of course, bandwidth-hungry Internet users may complain at the time a page with images takes to load up.

There was no actual problem in inserting images in any of the packages, and most of the popular formats such as BMP, JPG, GIF, etc, were supported. You could also resize images using the resize tool that appears when you position your mouse at the edges of the images.

NetObjects Fusion offered quite a bit of flexibility and accuracy in terms of positioning images on the Web page with the use of the easily identifiable grid lines. These served as guide marks and you could move the image accordingly or even snap to grid if you chose to. NetObjects has an entire toolbar that allows you to manipulate the images as per you liking.

Viewers and shakers: While, Microsoft FrontPage 2002 or Dreamweaver did not



Inserting and resizing images is easy in Namo Editor